

As I Was Saying

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First El Paso Park?

THE FIRST BASEBALL park in El Paso wasn't Dudley Field, Rio Grande Park on Wyoming avenue across from KROD or Washington Park.

The first one may have been Athletic Park at Eighth and Florence streets. It wasn't much. Bleachers that seated a few dozen people and a skinned diamond and grassless outfield.

But it served its purpose around 1910, according to Mauricio Cordero who managed the Internationals. The Boston Bloomer Girls played the Internationals in a game there and it no doubt drew one of the biggest crowds the little park ever had.

Cordero is 77. He wasn't the oldest "ex" among the old timers who attended the "Cooperstown on the Rio Grande" bash at the Falstaff Brewery Gardens last night. The oldest may have been Agustin Avila who's 79 and another one of the true old-timers in attendance was Joe Calamia, 75. His contemporaries say he was a fine little catcher.

Bill Dingwall, one of those at the affair, proudly displayed a picture of the 1912 Globe Mills team which played at Washington Park and was managed by Dave Crockett, the former cement and concrete contractor.

Cip Payo Was Player

THERE WAS A PICTURE of Cip Payo in all his youth. He was an outfielder on one of the old-time teams. It was my first inkling that Cip, a former prize fighter and for many years a referee, was also a former baseball player.

More than 100 showed up for the affair and they had so much fun that they vowed it'll become an annual affair. Sims Davis, Pete Leyva, Al Adkins, Marty Bauman and "Nosey" Graham got the first reunion going and Chris Fox and the State National Bank helped promote the affair. Chris gave it the name, "Cooperstown on the Rio Grande."

It wasn't exclusively a party for old, old timers who played around the turn of the century. Many who played in more recent years were there, too.

Semi-pro baseball probably flourished here best in the years preceding World War I and in the post-war years of the 1920s. It was the only baseball El Paso had. It was classified as semi-pro but a lot of the participants were good enough to play top grade pro ball and some did play in the majors.

With the coming of organized league baseball to El Paso in 1930, the semi-pros and amateurs had to take a back seat.

They Played for Blood

THE RIVALRY between the Peyton Packing Co. and the El Paso Electric Co. was something fierce. Their games used to pack the stands at Dudley Field.

Sims Davis had a big run of city championships with his Purity Bakers — seven in all. The last one was in 1929.

Many of the former semi-pro stars here have passed on. Leyva compiled a list of 65 who are deceased and that undoubtedly is not complete. There's a big toll of pitchers, including such prominent ones as Asa Porter, Manny Ponsford, Jodie McCormack, Jimmy Hicks, Lino Aguilar, "Jew" Weiss and others.

One of the pitchers present at the party was George Bell.

"I don't know why pitchers nowadays can't go nine innings," he said. "In my day a pitcher who started was expected to go all the way."

Somebody mentioned Bell's career, which included a brief whirl in the majors.

"Yes, I was up there for a cup of coffee," he said. "It was real good coffee, too."

Incident at Texas U.

BABE HARRIS, A PLAYER on the old Peyton team, was saying that modern players were better because they had more instruction than they had in his days.

Bus Gillett then mentioned one of the things taught him by Uncle Billy Disch at the University of Texas.

"Uncle Billy told me there would be a time when I was pitching that there would be a runner on third base and he would break for home plate.

"He coached me how to step off the rubber before I started my delivery. It happened one day. A Baylor runner was on third. He broke for home. I stepped off the rubber. And while I was off the rubber I threw the ball home. The batter hit the ball and it fell in safely. But the umpire called the batter out for interference."

Andy Cohen, who introduced all the old and young timers, ended by saying: "I am real proud to have grown up on El Paso baseball sandlots."